order to become a world power, Japan had no alternative but to modernize with the help of the West. There was no cultural stigma attached to the large-scale borrowing of Western knowledge systems, the educational set-up of the West and its advanced technology. This was very different from the Chinese response to the Western challenge.

While in Japan, the visiting Chinese scholars and activists were exposed to the vast pool of Western writings translated into Japanese. They began to inculcate a broader vision of Asia and the world and to explore China's place in what had been a distant and unfamiliar terrain for a long period. For the first time they explored the concept of pan-Asianism and how other Asian countries which were under colonial rule or under Western domination, such as China was, were dealing with the existential challenge from the West.

There were those who decried the materialism of the West and pointed to the superior spirituality of Asian or Eastern civilizations. The proceedings of the Parliament of World Religions in Chicago in 1893, where Swami Vivekananda spoke and where Eastern spirituality became an international brand, was picked up by the champions of pan-Asianism, who saw the resurgence of the East as an antidote to the West. Chinese intellectual discourse was influenced by these cross-currents.

~

The conservative backlash at the Qing court in the aftermath of the 100 Days of Reform made it even less capable of handling the gathering storm of the Boxer Rebellion and the humiliating defeat and plunder which followed. In its wake there were now the stirrings of a nationalist sentiment, a sense that to survive and to become strong, empire had to give way to nation. Western nations were strong, it was argued, because they had become nation-states with a strong national identity and solidarity. Modernity was not possible without China's transformation into a nation-state. Nationalism took on the form of Han nationalism and was directed against the Manchu rulers of the Qing dynasty as alien oppressors. There was no participation in this movement of other ethnic groups which made